



Slovenian / University

Read the Space, Not the Plan

Ideas Worth Measuring



An invitation

A plan tells you what a space is for. It rarely tells you what a space is actually used for once people get to it. At Slop University, the distance between the two is not treated as noise to smooth over — it is treated as a finding.

The University's researchers spend as much time watching what a courtyard, a queue, a dashboard, or a rostered process does in practice as they spend reading the document that assigned it a single purpose. Sometimes the plan holds up. More often, the space has quietly taken on a life the plan never anticipated, and closing that gap — naming it, measuring it, deciding what to do about it — has become one of the University's most consistent research exports.

This is not a brochure about buildings, though a courtyard or two makes an appearance. It is an invitation to a way of working: read the record before the plan, and hold the plan to what the record shows. The pages that follow set out where that habit lives across the University's schools, the published work it has produced, and the people carrying it forward.



The short version

A quick account of how the University spends its attention.



Two schools, one method

Every project starts by watching what a space, a system, or a process actually does, before any plan gets the final word.



Researchers across campus

Our researchers work across a shared programme, comparing what is measured against what is felt, done, and observed.



Every finding, traceable

Every completed study carries a persistent identifier and resolves on the University's own research repository, open for anyone to check.

Where ideas count

Sensing before deciding

The School of Emergent Priorities studies how a priority is sensed long before it becomes a commitment — the scanning exercise, the working group, the line in a plan that will later be pointed to as the moment a direction was set. Its flagship group, the Trajectory Analytics Group, follows a priority from its first appearance in a horizon-scanning exercise through to whatever it becomes once budgets, committees, and successive planning cycles have had their say.

The School's researchers take the same interest in priorities that quietly lapse as in the ones that are formally retired, and in the language that survives a planning cycle even after the initiative behind it has moved on. The aim throughout is not to predict which priorities will land, but to understand why some readings of the horizon turn into durable commitments and others evaporate the moment the meeting ends.



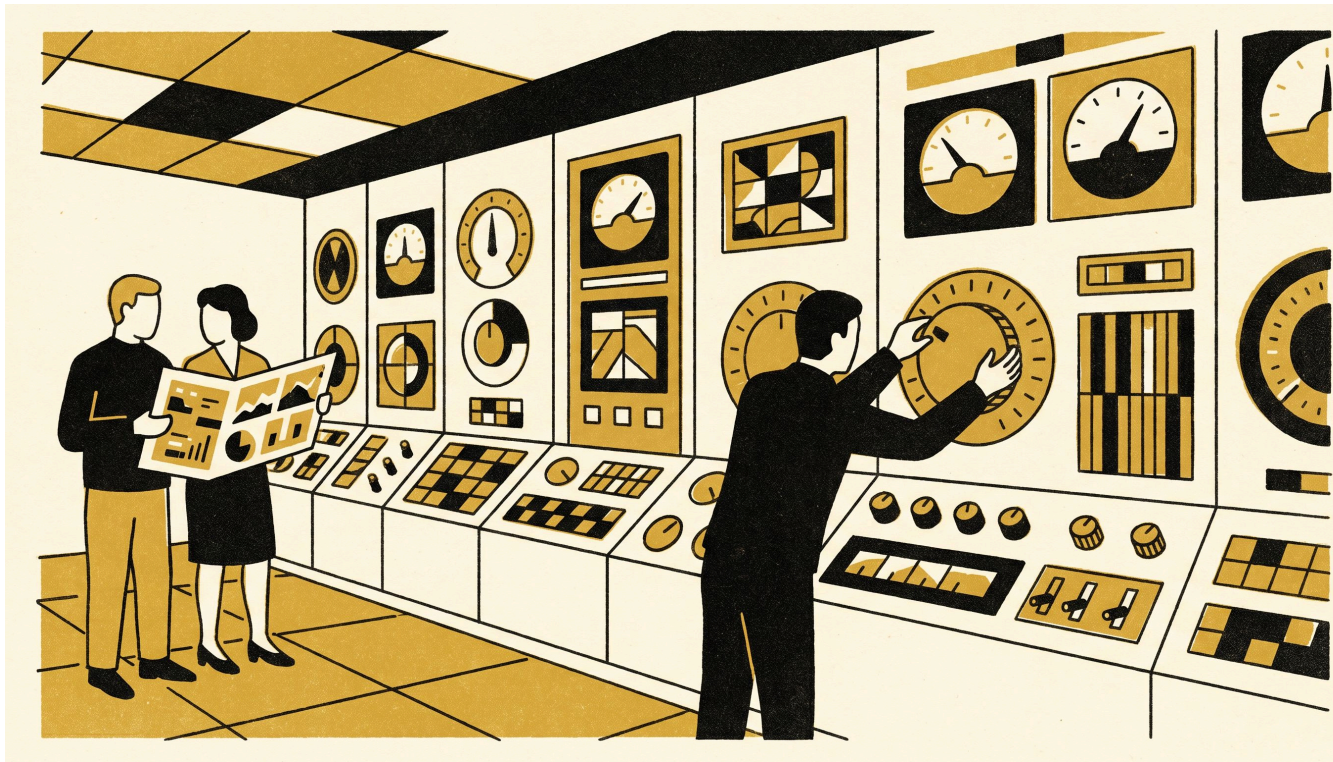
“A horizon-scanning exercise only earns its name once someone comes back and checks what actually arrived.”

— Verity Marris, Professor and Director, Trajectory Analytics Group, School of Emergent Priorities

Reading the record, not just the dashboard

The School of Continuous Improvement studies the instruments an institution builds to measure itself — the dashboards, indices, and scorecards that are meant to stand in for the thing they track. Its flagship lab, the Adaptive Metrics Lab, treats every such instrument as a claim worth testing: does the number on the tile move for the reason the tile suggests, or for something else entirely?

That question runs through the School’s wider evaluation-ecosystem agenda, from the Indicator Commons’ shared library of measures to the Living Dashboard’s always-on self-report. The School’s researchers are as interested in indicators an institution never formally retires as in the ones that quietly stop being read, and in what a metric comes to stand for once the practice it was meant to describe has moved on without it.



“A dashboard that agrees with itself is not the same as a dashboard that agrees with the building.”

— Casimir Beng, Associate Professor and Lead, Adaptive Metrics Lab, School of Continuous Improvement

What the space is actually for

Some of the University’s most consistent findings begin somewhere unglamorous: a courtyard, a queue, a shared appliance, a folder of hand-lettered signs nobody authorised. None of these things come with their own research budget. All of them come with a plan, a standard, or a policy that assigned them a single, tidy purpose — and a use pattern, once anyone actually watches, that rarely stays inside it.

Researchers across both schools treat this gap as a standing invitation rather than an embarrassment. A space is read the way a dashboard is read: not by what it was designed to do, but by what it demonstrably does once people, weather, and habit get a say. The record — swipe logs, sign-up sheets, a walked audit, an afternoon with a clipboard — is given at least as much authority as the document that planned the space in the first place.



“We do not ask whether the plan was reasonable. We ask what happened once nobody was reading it.”

— Dagny Okafor, Lecturer and Convenor, Evaluation of Evaluation, School of Continuous Improvement

Read the work

Four recent studies, each testing what a plan, a sign, or a score assumed against what campus actually did.

- **Posted Early, Swooped All the Same** — tests whether warning campus of a returning magpie ahead of time changes anything the standing reactive approach doesn’t already achieve. [doi:10.5555/slop.gwvlkm](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.gwvlkm)
- **Confidently Filled, Rarely Correlated** — checks the staff car-park priority score against independent measures of commuting need, and finds out what the score is actually tracking. [doi:10.5555/slop.ojetat](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.ojetat)
- **What the Standard Doesn’t Say** — catalogues how often hand-lettered signage returns to a wall within weeks of the University’s Approved Signage Standard taking it down. [doi:10.5555/slop.bf93qp](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.bf93qp)

- **Credited on Installation Day** — audits a same-day vending-machine upgrade against six months of transaction and complaint data, and against the index that praised it before the data arrived. doi:10.5555/slop.vcpl4k

The people behind the work

- **Verity Marris**, Professor and Director, Trajectory Analytics Group, School of Emergent Priorities, studies how a priority hardens into a commitment and outlives the conditions that first justified it.
- **Casimir Beng**, Associate Professor and Lead, Adaptive Metrics Lab, School of Continuous Improvement, studies measurement systems that improve the things they measure, and what happens when they stop.
- **Kwame Lindqvist**, Associate Professor, School of Emergent Priorities, studies the point at which a priority acquires a budget line well before it acquires a settled definition.

Your next step

None of this works as a spectator sport. The University's research is published as it happens, under a persistent identifier, on its own repository — not held back for a retrospective. If a plan in your own institution has quietly stopped matching the space it describes, that gap is exactly the kind of finding Slop University's researchers are built to chase down.

Read the published work, follow a school's agenda as it develops, or get in touch about a space, a system, or a process you suspect has drifted from its own paperwork. The University's schools — Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement — work across settings from a single courtyard to a whole-of-campus footprint, and take on the comparison at whatever scale it's needed.

Start at slop.university and read the record for yourself.



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